



△ TAKE OFF AND LANDING

Getting airborne from water or land requires a run to gather speed, before the swan's wings can generate sufficient lift. When coming in to land on water, the large webbed feet and wings act as brakes.

◁ GOING FOR A RIDE

Cygnets accompany their parents for several weeks, sometimes taking a ride on one of their backs while they are still small.



Greater flamingo

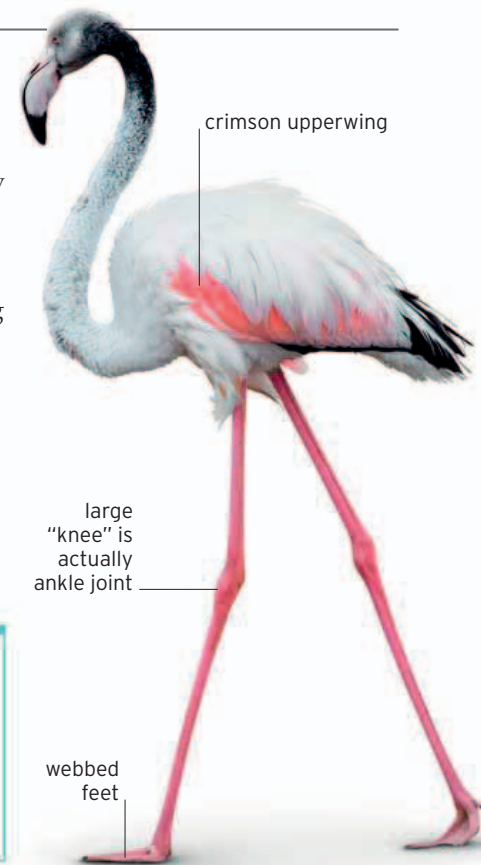
Phoenicopterus roseus

Flamingos feed unlike any other bird. The angled bill, held upside down and swept sideways, works like a sieve, gathering tiny invertebrates and algae from the salty water. If disturbed, flamingos run to take flight. The slim body, long neck, and trailing legs form a cross with the crimson-and-black wings.

▷ WALKING ON STILTS

Long legs mean the greater flamingo can wade in deep water with its long, sinuous neck reaching down to its toes to feed.

- ↔ 4–5 ft (1.2–1.5 m)
- ⚖ Up to 9 lb (4 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🦋 Krill, shrimp, algae
- 🏠 🌊 🌊
- 📍 SW. Europe, Asia, Africa



Pied avocet

Recurvirostra avosetta

The pied avocet has the most upcurved bill of any European bird. The delicate, sensitive, slightly flat tip is swept horizontally through soft, saline mud, and tiny shrimp and other creatures are located by touch.

Few suitable natural nesting sites of the pied avocet remain in Europe, but many colonies have formed on artificially created lagoons and salt pans, most of which are nature reserves. In winter, the avocets collect in flocks, hundreds strong, on suitably mild, wet, muddy estuaries.

▷ OPEN NEST

Avocets lay their eggs almost directly on dried mud. Colonies are vulnerable to predation despite the combined defensive efforts of the adults.

- ↔ 17–18 in (43–46 cm)
- ⚖ 8–14 oz (226–400 g)
- ⊗ Common
- 🦋 Crustaceans, insects
- 🏠 🌊 🌊 🌊
- 📍 Europe, Asia, Africa

